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DREAMS, STREET CRED AND A BRUTAL WAKE-UP CALL

PEOPLE DAYDREAM about money and cars. I daydreamed about my shot selection.

My visualization – my habit of staying up at night and thinking about my shots and playing them out in my head, one after the other – has decreased over the years, but it's still there. At one point, I used to play out the whole match in my head, but I don't get anywhere close to that these days.

Back in the day, I would visualize my warm-up, how my body felt, how I felt, how powerful my arm felt, how I released the ball, how it drifted, landed, skidded and spun. For the batting, I would go through my shots and imagine where I would play them, how my legs would feel when I'd shuffle, how my hands would ring after a big shot. I would go through the whole day, motion by motion, one ball after another, in my head.

In the middle of all this, friends came and went. In 1992, when we shifted to Gulshan-e-Iqbal – Block 13, a more upscale neighbourhood than our previous address – it was a different world. The roads were wider, the cricketers I played with were older and more experienced and the tape-ball game was better; tougher actually. Even though it was a bit of a change – there were no Pashtuns or relatives in the area – it didn't matter. There were no politics when it came to cricket, certainly not in my neighbourhood.

That's where I started finding my confidence too, by playing with the older guys and improving my street game while staying a regular in the U-16 circuit. When I entered my teens, I started hanging out late at night with the local hotshots, some gang of friends or the other, some with political connections, doing the things those with 'connections' do. Hanging out after hours on the streets with the guys soon became part of my routine. Then, one day, my elder brother, Tariq, changed it all for me. With a slap.

It was a late night out, when I was chilling with some of the guys, just messing about, when